

Establishing an Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Coalition on Climate and Health

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Problem Identification:

There is currently no coordinated direct feedback mechanism for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islanders to provide feedback to the Department of Health and Aged Care and the Department of Climate Change, Energy, Environment and Water (DCCEEW).

The 2023 [National Health and Climate Strategy](#) noted that, 'consultation[s] with First Nations peak bodies and organisations identified a governance gap at the intersection between the health of First Nations peoples and climate change.'

This means that climate and health decisions may fail to integrate important First Nations perspectives. The Lowitja Institute reported in 2023, that climate and health decision-makers may lack the [resources and capacity](#) needed for meaningful consultations. The Lowitja Institute also found a lack of coordination and ineffective communication across various government engagement processes made it difficult for decision-makers to decide which consultations to prioritise.

Context:

The [Lowitja Institute](#) has highlighted that climate change 'will have a wide variety of impacts' on the, 'health and wellbeing of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples.' In their [2023 position paper](#), they emphasised that Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Peoples' deep knowledge of Country, and holistic understanding of health and climate are integral to shaping national policies. Nonetheless, current government efforts at community consultations face several barriers.

The Lowitja Institute further noted that, 'lack of resources, inefficient government processes, and the [siloing of climate-related](#) issues across government departments,' has resulted in either too

little engagement or excessive, poorly coordinated consultations. Further, in a [2021 discussion paper](#), Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities shared that even when they were consulted extensively by state and national governments, they lacked the [resources and capacity](#) to engage effectively. Respondents also stated that they were asked the same questions across separate engagement processes.

Given this, the Lowitja Institute has called for the creation of a [National Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Coalition on Climate and Health](#). They have proposed this [Coalition](#) could work across government departments as a partner in developing effective and meaningful policy on climate and health. The Lowitja Institute says this could improve coordination, ensuring steady support and funding for Indigenous leadership in climate and health policy.

There is domestic precedent of recognising the intersection of climate change and health, as exemplified through the '[2023 National Health and Climate Strategy](#)'.

Solution Identification:

Establish a National Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Coalition on Climate and Health, following the Lowitja model, outlined in their 2023 position paper.

This could enable stronger collaboration between Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities and government bodies as well as address concerns about ineffective government consultation processes.

Advice:

The Department of Health and Aged Care should work with the DCCEEW to establish a National Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Coalition on Climate and Health at the next opportunity.

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Public Support:

1. [The Lowitja Institute](#)



2. [The Climate and Health Alliance](#)



3. [CRE-STRIDE](#)



4. [NHLF](#)



5. [HEAL Network](#)



Lived Experience:

Robert, a proud Aboriginal man from Western Australia, is confronting worsening health issues in his community as a result of climate change. He felt that despite being engaged frequently by state and national governments, the consultations were poorly coordinated and led to little concrete action. Robert expressed that the rules and processes seemed inconsistent and unfair, as the community's deep connection to their traditional lands was crucial for their well-being. He was particularly upset that, as an Aboriginal man, he was not able to influence climate and health policies effectively through these consultations. Robert felt that the lack of a fully resourced body to support Indigenous leadership in these

discussions only exacerbated the challenges, preventing him and his community from having a meaningful role in shaping a resilient future.

Where to go to learn more:

- [Lowitja Institute's Policy Position Paper on Climate and Health](#) - Lowitja Institute is Australia's only national Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander community-controlled health research institute. Their policy position paper draws on their 2023 community engagement discussions with key Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander academics and previous work in climate and health.
- [Lowitja Institute's 2024 Media Release](#) - Lowitja Institute and leading climate and health organisations call on the Australian Government to empower Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander leadership by funding a National Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Coalition on Climate and Health.
- [Lowitja Institute's Business Case](#) - The Business Case provides an in-depth description of the Coalition, membership model and the estimated funding required for its functioning.

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Conflict of interest / acknowledgment statement:

One of the authors for this paper is Indigenous Australian and therefore has a personal interest in this policy proposal.

Support

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